

Most Meaningful Journey Begins After the Victory In *Frieren: Beyond Journey's End*

Frieren: Beyond Journey's End redefines fantasy by focusing on emotional aftermath instead of the heroic adventure.

By Lucia Lorenz

How do you make a fantasy anime successful when fantasy is currently being so overdone in the media? That was my first thought when I was seeing all the positive box office success the newly released anime *Frieren: Beyond Journey's End* was receiving. Sitting down with my hot tea in hand, I press watch and stumble upon the ending to a fantasy story. The opening scene shows all the heroes already defeated the evil king, and the land is now saved. Most fantasy stories end when the hero defeats evil and returns home. *Frieren* begins at that exact point. Intrigued, I continue watching, and through time jumps, we fast forward to when one of the heroes dies of old age, a character named Himmel. *Frieren*, our main character, who has been out traveling, comes back to attend the funeral of her late friend, realizing she is struck by grief and love. From the first episode of this show, it is clear it is doing something different from a traditional fantasy. It doesn't address the traditional structure of "how do we save the world", but instead begins with grieving and how the world moves on after the successful battle. *Frieren: Beyond Journey's End* succeeds with audiences and viewers because it redefines the fantasy genre for an audience that is exhausted by powerful protagonists, constant action sequences, and chosen one arcs, replacing them with reflection and meditation on grief, time, and emotional distance instead.

Frieren: Beyond Journey's End stands out significantly to anime fandoms by rejecting the assumption that audiences want fantasy that participates in spectacle and action-packed sequences, but instead prefer slower pacing, introspection, and aftermath reflection. In past popular and highly consumed anime fantasies, there are themes that are constantly prevalent. For instance, a popular structural theme within anime fantasy is called isekai. This type of anime is when a character becomes reincarnated or transported into a fantasy world from the real world. Examples of anime where this can be found are *That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime* and *Solo Leveling*. Another form of fantasy within anime is action-packed battling and fighting some evil for glory, such as in *Sword Art Online*. But *Frieren: Beyond Journey's End* has not participated in any of these famous anime fantasy themes and has become just as successful as the other existing anime above. This then expresses that audiences are growing tired of the same

old patterns and structure of this fantasy formula already created. But a new idea is that audiences want fantasy to have more emotional depth and reflection rather than fast-paced escalation, glory, or the same structural plot patterns.

An example of how *Frieren: Beyond Journey's End* truly morphs fantasy anime to focus more on the emotional aftermath rather than the heroic victory is when Frieren goes to Himmel's funeral. Himmel in the story is one of the heroes who helped Frieren fight the evil demon king and save the day. After that time passed, Frieren went off to work as a freelance mage, not truly understanding how time was passing. The reason for this was because she is also an elf, so she barely ages, and time doesn't really make her change. So when she found out Himmel had passed because of old age, she at first didn't show much emotion, even at the funeral. Not until a year later did she feel the loss of her friend and finally cry, teaching Frieren that human relationships become emotionally abstract until they are gone. Frieren's lack of expressing emotion at the funeral is a metaphor for this emotional avoidance she is trying to obtain, but when she finally breaks, it shows that no matter how much you hold in an emotion, it eventually always comes out. The slow pacing of this scene, as well, is a symbolic representation of how regret can build and grow as time passes. Frieren's emotional detachment at Himmel's funeral reveals the argument that time and emotional understanding are intertwined and that people often fail to recognize the significance of relationships until some type of loss forces reflection. What this makes clear is that *Frieren: Beyond Journey's End* is not focused on the fantastical journey itself, but rather wants to highlight the emotional climax in the aftermath of that journey that has been created within Frieren.

As the story progresses, one of its most moving moments comes when the main character, Frieren, revisits a place that she had once been with her fellow heroes, telling that anime fantasy conventions want to focus on a narrative of remembrance and mourning rather than one of adventure. This specific episode is when Frieren stumbles upon a village that she and her fellow heroes once saved, and they put up a statue of Himmel, which they ask if she could clean because plant life had overtaken it. In the process of cleaning, the lady who was in charge of the statue told her she wanted to plant flowers around it but didn't know what kind. Frieren suggests Himmel's favorite flowers, Blue Moon Weed, to plant around the statue, and she has a flashback of when Himmel told her his favorite flowers. This whole powerful scene reveals how places and locations can bring back memories not just of past times, but can remind you of specific things about a person you might not have thought about in a while. It also reveals that those memories might not have meant much in the moment and might have seemed insignificant, but become so much more important emotionally in the future. Overall, *Frieren: Beyond Journey's End* shows that going back matters more than moving forward. Revisiting old roads and forgotten conversations turns the fantasy quest into a story about realizing what you missed.

This anime plays within the fantasy genre unlike any has done before, revealing that the genre doesn't need big battles to be successful and appealing to the audience, but can instead be slower-paced and reflective. *Frieren: Beyond Journey's End* succeeds because it trusts emotional stillness and patience. This might be exactly why the anime community is finding so much success with this anime right now, because it doesn't exhaust the fantasy genre's overdone patterns. It is also desired because people yearn for cozier, softer storytelling, especially when people live in a world where everything moves so fast. There is this need to slow down into a story that can be more of a welcomed escape than one with fast fantasy-driven plots. Fantasy doesn't need bigger battles. Sometimes its most meaningful story begins after the battle is already over.